Netherlands: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- The Netherlands is most exposed in upstream nuclear, upstream coal and downstream gas, where its Energy Security is higher than only 4%, 13% and 18% of the other economies scored. A trade deficit and a coal shortfall pull the upstream scores down.[1]
- Its strongest openings are in downstream batteries, midstream nuclear and upstream nuclear, where its Economic Opportunity is higher than 97%, 95% and 93% of the other economies scored. Investment pushes up the battery score and trade the nuclear scores.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, the Strategic Index puts upstream nuclear 1st among the Netherlands' own sectors; its policy activity is in the "middle" group.[1]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates Spain highest for the Netherlands, as a reliable supplier; it is also the Netherlands' 6th trade partner. China ranks 4th among its trade partners but 44th on Partnership Strength.[1,2]

1. Energy security risks and why

Energy Security measures how well a country can rely on what it needs in a sector, compared with other economies. Of the Netherlands' 30 placed sectors (those comparable on both scores), 9 sit in the two low-energy-security corners: 8 in the Upgrade corner and 1 in the Secure corner. Compared with other economies in each sector, its Energy Security is lowest in upstream nuclear (0.16), upstream coal (0.25) and downstream gas (0.41). It scores higher than only 4%, 13% and 18% of the other 174, 95 and 98 economies scored in these sectors. Both upstream nuclear and upstream coal sit in the Upgrade corner, and downstream gas in the Secure corner.[1]

Its high-priority sectors, chosen from the Upgrade corner by Strategic Index rank, are upstream nuclear, midstream batteries and upstream electric grid. In upstream nuclear, the trade category pulls the score down. Its trade deficit in these goods was 0.1% of GDP in 2023, a measure on which it scores higher than only 1% of the other economies. For context, its largest suppliers in 2024 were Canada (63.0% of imports totalling USD 1.29 bn), the United States (21.7%) and France (14.5%). In midstream batteries, also in the Upgrade corner, the trade deficit was 0.3% of GDP and its share of world exports 1.4%, both in 2023.[1,2,3]

Energy imports pull upstream coal down: coal production minus consumption was -0.19 EJ in 2025. In downstream gas, energy access pulls the score down: gas use per person changed by -30.6% over the years to 2025.[4,5]

2. Economic opportunities and why

Economic Opportunity measures how well placed a country is to create value in a sector, from exports and related capabilities to investment, costs and demand. Of the 30 placed sectors, 27 sit in the two high-opportunity corners: 19 in the Grow corner, with high energy security, and 8 in the Upgrade corner, with low energy security. Its Economic Opportunity ranks highest in downstream batteries, midstream nuclear and upstream nuclear, higher than 97%, 95% and 93% of the other 138, 153 and 174 economies scored.[1]

Investment pushes downstream batteries up: it scores higher than 96% of the other economies on annual investment and 98% on growth in investment. Trade pushes midstream nuclear up: its share of world exports was 5.6% in 2023, and its revealed comparative advantage 4.17 in 2024. It thus exports more of these goods than the size of its trade would suggest. Trade also pushes upstream nuclear up: on export feasibility, how close these goods are to what it already exports well, it scores higher than 99% of the other economies.[1,3,6]

For context, the United States took 45.7% of its midstream nuclear exports of USD 1.31 bn in 2024, Sweden 23.7% and France 19.0%. The paper's framework associates the Upgrade corner, where upstream nuclear sits, with leapfrogging: building capability where opportunity is high and energy security low.[1,2]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks the Netherlands' own sectors by combining opportunity, security need, policy activity, the supply-chain stage and the technology's low-emission value. On the paper's weighting, it puts upstream nuclear 1st, upstream wind 2nd, upstream batteries 3rd, midstream batteries 4th and midstream green hydrogen 5th among its own sectors. At 0.67, upstream nuclear leads by 0.025; security need adds 0.253 to its score and opportunity 0.165. The sectors after it are almost tied, with gaps of 0.003, 0.003 and 0.002. Its allied pick, the top upstream or midstream sector after a resource screen, is midstream batteries; the leading upstream sectors fall to that screen.[1]

Policy activity counts International Energy Agency Policies and Measures records and reads the Climate Action Tracker rating against each technology; data-based priority is the Strategic Index without its policy term. Splitting its sectors into thirds on each measure, top priority meets the most policy in upstream batteries, midstream batteries and midstream green hydrogen. Its 1st and 2nd sectors, upstream nuclear and upstream wind, are in the top third on data-based priority but in the "middle" policy group. No top-priority sector has the least policy. Bottom priority meets the most policy in downstream green hydrogen and the least in 7 sectors, every oil and coal sector among them. As an EU member, the Netherlands carries the Climate Action Tracker rating Insufficient (November 2024); it has 265 Policies and Measures records of its own, 144 naming a technology. For context, Global Trade Alert lists 637 active industrial-policy measures that apply to the Netherlands, 521 of them EU-wide.[1,7,8,9]

4. Partnership priorities and why

The Partnership Strength Index rates partners from the Netherlands' viewpoint as reliable suppliers (Friendshore), as export markets (Partnership Opportunity) and, for middle- and lower-income partners, by Development Potential. It ranks Spain 1st, the United States 2nd, Germany 3rd, Belgium 4th and Italy 5th of 191 partners. Spain and the United States each stand out as a reliable supplier; for Spain the best sectors include upstream nuclear, upstream solar, upstream wind, upstream batteries and upstream electric vehicles. Germany, Belgium and Italy each stand out as an export market.[1]

Today's ties follow these priorities closely. Each of these partners is a priority partner with strong ties today. By average share across its energy-goods baskets, Germany is its 1st trade partner, Belgium its 2nd, the United States its 3rd, Italy its 5th and Spain its 6th. They share membership of NATO with the Netherlands and vote in the same bloc at the UN. China ranks 4th among its trade partners but 44th on Partnership Strength, and the countries vote in opposite blocs.[1,2,10,11]

As a partner to the coalition, the Netherlands ranks 3rd of 192 economies on Partnership Strength averaged over the core members' viewpoints. In the allied network design, which spreads upstream and midstream production across coalition members, its largest derived shares are 2.8% of midstream nuclear, 1.3% of midstream green hydrogen and 1.2% of upstream solar.[1,12]

5. Data notes and caveats

The Country Insights page shows these data as of 12 October 2026.

- Scores compare the Netherlands with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms.
- All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings.
- Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order.
- In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; the Netherlands' shares are derived from its weight within the EU.
- The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; the Netherlands carries the EU's rating.
- The Netherlands' counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records.
- Trade figures count trade with other EU members.
- Industrial-policy measures from the Global Trade Alert, New Industrial Policy Observatory, October 2026 extract (as of 5 October 2026) are context only, outside the Policy index.

Sources

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.
Allied Industrial Base Explorer, Country Insights: Netherlands